MZUZU UNIVERSITY

FACULTY OF INFORMATION SCIENCE AND COMMUNICATIONS

DEPARTMENT OF INFORMATION SCIENCE

Diploma in Information Science
(Weekend Programme)

END OF SEMESTER EXAMINATION

COMM 1101 COMMUNICATION STUDIES 1

DATE: Friday, September 29, 2017 (8:00 - 10:30 pm) **TIME ALLOWED: 2½ Hours**

READ ALL INSTRUCTIONS OUTLINED BELOW VERY CAREFULLY

i. Answer **ALL** Questions
ii. Use Appropriate Grammar and Language
iii. Write Neatly. Dirty Work May Attract Loss of Marks
iv. Present Your Work in Well Organised Paragraphs
v. Each question MUST Start on a Fresh Answer Sheet

Question 1

Read the passage below and summarise it in note-form. **(15 marks)**

PURPOSES OF LISTENING

Speakers' motivations for speechmaking vary from situation to situation just as listeners' purposes for paying attention vary. Researchers have identified five types of listening (each serving a different purpose): (a) appreciative, (b) discriminative, (c) therapeutic, (d) comprehension, and (e) critical.

Appreciative Listening

Appreciative listening focuses on something other than the primary message. People who are principally concerned with participating in the experience are appreciative listeners. Some listeners enjoy seeing a famous speaker. Other listeners enjoy the art of good public speaking, pleasing vocal modulation, clever uses of language, impressive phraseology, and the skillful use of supporting materials. Still other listeners simply like to attend special occasions such as inaugurations, dedications, and graduations.

Discriminative Listening

Discriminative listening requires listeners to draw conclusions from the way a message is presented rather than from what is said. In discriminative listening, people seek to understand what the speaker really thinks, believes, or feels. You're engaging in discriminative listening when you draw conclusions about how angry your parents are with you, based not on what they say, but on how they say it. Journalists listening to the way that a message is presented often second-guess the attitudes of national leaders on foreign policy. Performers, of course, can convey emotions such as anger or exhilaration to audiences through their delivery alone. In each of these examples, an important dimension of listening is based on relatively sophisticated inferences drawn from—rather than found in—messages.

Therapeutic Listening

Therapeutic listening is intended to provide emotional support to the speaker. It is more typical of interpersonal than public communication—the therapeutic listener acts as a sounding board for a speaker attempting to talk through a problem, work out a difficult situation, or express deep emotions. Sometimes, however, therapeutic listening occurs in public speaking situations such as when a sports star apologizes for unprofessional behavior, a religious convert describes a soul-saving experience, or a classmate reviews a personal problem and thanks friends for their help in solving it. In therapeutic listening, special social bonding occurs between speaker and listener. Consider the communication of joy that occurs when listeners react to someone who wants to tell others about a new relationship, a new baby, a promotion at work, or an award at school.

Listening for Comprehension

Listening for comprehension occurs when the listener wants to gain additional information or insights provided by the speaker. This is probably the form of listening with which you are most familiar. When you listen to radio or TV news programs, to classroom lectures on the four principal causes of World War II, or to an orientation official previewing your school's new registration process, you're listening to understand—to comprehend information, ideas, and processes.

Critical Listening

Critical listening requires listeners to both interpret and evaluate the message. The most sophisticated kind of listening is critical listening. It demands that auditors go beyond understanding the message to interpreting it, judging its strengths and weaknesses, and assigning it some value. You'll practice this sort of listening in your class. You may also use critical listening as you evaluate commercials, political campaign speeches, advice from career counselors, or arguments offered by controversial talk show guests. When you listen critically, you decide to accept or reject ideas. You may also resolve to act or delay action on the message. . . .

The variety of listening purposes has serious implications for both listeners and speakers. Appreciative listeners are highly selective, watching for metaphors, responding to speaking tones, and searching out memorable phrasings. At the other extreme, critical listeners work hard to catch relevant details, to judge the soundness of competing arguments and to rationally decide whether to accept ideas. Therapeutic listeners decide when to positively reinforce speakers through applause or other signs of approval, and those listening for comprehension distinguish between important and unimportant information. Finally, discriminative listeners search for clues to unspoken ideas or feelings that are relevant to themselves. As you think about your own listening purposes, you'll find yourself adapting your listening behavior to the speaking situation more carefully.

—Gronbeck, *Principles of Speech C*

Question 2

a) In your own words define 'communication barriers'.
(3 marks)

b) Mention three types of communication barriers and explain how they can be prevented.
(7 marks)

c) Explain **four** factors that can negatively affect listening in a classroom situation.
(4 marks)

d) Give **two** advantages of written communication over oral communication. **(4 marks)**

e) Why is it that communication has no reverse? **(2 marks)**

Question 3

Read the passage below and answer the following questions.

1 Interviewing is a form of communication used widely in the media—in newspapers and magazines as well as on talk radio and on television. It is the television talk show, however, that has most captured the attention of the media consumer, and it is a media phenomenon that needs to be examined.

2 In an article entitled, "Talk Shows Are Good for You," frequent talk show psychologist Gilda Carle (1995) identifies some of the benefits of talk shows. Among these are that they show us new communication techniques, teach us about new topics, break down myths, show us celebrities are real people, and make us laugh. And, media critic A.J. Jacobs (1995) notes additional values:

- Talk shows are "models of diversity." All cultures are represented on talk shows.
- Talk shows also "break new ground" and discuss issues that are too often neglected by the mainstream shows; cross dressing, interracial relationships, and child abuse, for example, are frequent topics of talk shows.
- Talk shows are in the American tradition. Television viewers are interested in people like themselves and enjoy seeing a person's private life exposed.
- Talk shows make the viewers' problems seem minor.

3 Mass communication researcher Janice Peck (1995) notes, from an analysis of shows hosted by Oprah Winfrey and Sally Jessy Raphael, that the talk shows have made public issues that were once hidden and give a public platform to groups that have generally not had media exposure (for example, women).

4 Consider some of the disadvantages, however. For example, talk shows dispense advice on a variety of issues—especially in the monologue that closes many of the shows—from someone with little or no professional training in the field. Do you really want to take relationship advice from Ricki Lake or Montel Williams or Richard Bey? They regularly give communication advice with no basis in scientific research and generally foster myths about communication. Perhaps the most prevalent myth about communication is that communication will solve all problems and that the more communication a couple has the better the relationship will be.

5 Talk shows are entertaining but they often present themselves as educational, as therapy for the masses, and as arbiters of how you and your family

and your friends should live their lives. Talk shows also create an impression that the world is divided into two extremes. Polarizing guests—the gay activist and the fundamentalist preacher, the liberal and the conservative—makes for interesting debate and generally holds viewer attention, but the extremes do not represent the world. They are extreme precisely because they do not represent the vast majority of the world.

Talk shows also give the impression that therapy takes one hour—the problem is introduced , the therapy is given, the catharsis takes place, and the cure emerges. Of course, we know that it doesn't happen like that and yet it is difficult to dismiss examples shown repeatedly and with generally good production values. Some shows make continued therapy available for their guests and this is certainly one gesture in the right direction. Most shows, however, seem to imply that the problem is over when the show is over and that the problem is resolved. Janice Peck (1995, p. 76) argues: "the programs discourage critical engagement with and reflection on those problems in favor of immediate identification and catharsis and undermine the ability to take these problems seriously in the service of making them entertaining."

Still another effect seems to be the sanctioning or approval of violating societal or cultural rules. Talk shows present what is to many "unthinkable" and make it thinkable. It ultimately positions these behaviors within the range of normalcy (Abt 1995). For example, by giving a platform to pregnant teenagers who continue to smoke, drink, and use drugs and who refuse to alter their behavior (as on a 1995 Sally Jessy Raphael show), the talk show may be saying in effect that this really cannot be that bad. The same is true for shows devoted to gangs that rob for pleasure, children who abuse their parents, or spouses who deceive their mates. Depending on your own political and social values, you can add a lot more examples. The more you come into contact with a pattern of behavior, the more normal it will appear to you. If this effect is real—and if talk shows can only thrive based on the degree to which their guests can shock the audience—then the standards for acceptable (socially sanctioned) behavior are likely to change in the direction of these extremes.